

SWEET BRIAR

Rosa rubiginosa

Sweet briar, or eglantine rose, is one of the most attractive of a range of wild roses that brighten hedgerows and scrub across Europe into Asia and Africa. They have five-petalled flowers that are usually white or pale pink. To non-botanists, they seem rather similar, and are often called “dog roses”. This derogatory name is said to be because they are less showy and strongly scented than the garden roses bred by horticulturalists over centuries, although some would argue they have a more subtle beauty and delicate scent than their fancy relatives. Many are prickly shrubs with scrambling, arched stems, for which “briar” is a descriptive term. Sweet briar has deep pink flowers and leaves that emit the scent of apples when crushed. It has been introduced to the Americas and Australia, where it has become invasive.

✓ DEVELOPING HIPS

The flower base swells to form a succulent hip, technically a “false fruit” because it is not formed from the ovary. This contains numerous, small, one-seeded “pips” which are the true fruits.

sepals remain as a leafy tuft



✓ ROSEBUD

Sepals around the flower bud protect the developing petals and fertile parts. The stubble of glandular hairs may insulate the bud and repel pests.



STAMENS >

Numerous stamens cluster in whorls around the centre of the sweet briar flower. They have pale stalks and bright yellow anthers, which produce copious amounts of pollen.



THORNS >

Hooked thorns, interspersed with strong bristles, discourage large animals from grazing the leaves.



SIZE Erect stems to 2 m (6½ ft) tall
HABITAT Open scrub, hedgerows, parks, and roadsides
DISTRIBUTION Europe to Asia, introduced elsewhere

prickly, spreading stem

leaflet teeth fringed with stalked glands

✓ UNDERSIDE OF LEAF

The under surface of the leaf is densely hairy, mixed with many brownish, stalked glands. These release sweet-smelling terpene chemicals that may deter grazers.



leaflet with saw-toothed edge



< RIPE HIPS

Hips shed their sepal tuft before ripening. Ripe, red hips are rich in vitamin C and are eaten by thrushes and pigeons, which spread the seeds in their droppings.

